

iPhone 4 to hit India soon

Bharti Airtel is in talks with Apple and plan to launch iPhone4 by September end

Antennagate

Apple to give iPhone4 with protective case to prevent signal strength issues caused due to gripping the iPhone with bare hands

Investigating iOS4

So is the iOS4 as great as it's touted to be? We decided to give it a spin

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Apple's latest iteration of its mobile operating system was launched amidst much fanfare along with the iPhone 4. The operating system previously known as iPhone OS got a slimmer nomenclature in the form of iOS. Along with the new name, Apple has introduced a lot of features in iOS4.

Since Apple iPhones and iPods span across generations, you have to know which device is actually compatible with iOS4. Apple iOS4 runs smoothly on iPhone 4, iPhone 3GS and iPod touch (3rd gen). For iPhone 3G and iPod touch (2nd gen) users, certain features like multi-tasking will not be accessible, as it is too taxing on the hardware of these devices. iPhone 2G and iPod touch 1st gen users will have to stick with iOS 3.1.3 as it cannot upgrade to iOS4. Finally, iPad will start getting upgraded with iOS4 sometime in October-November.

For our testing purpose we used an iPod touch (3rd generation). We pretty much got all the iOS4 features except the ones associated with the phone. So here's a lowdown of our experience with the iOS4.

Multi-tasking

This is one feature that was sorely missing in an Apple mobile product, which was

already present in other mobile operating systems like Android. Unlike pre-iOS4 when multi-tasking was only allowed with Apple apps, the multitasking function is now available for third-party applications. So you can listen to an online streaming music app and at the same time write your Notes or update your Twitter account. However, multi-tasking on the iPhone or iPod is different from that on a desktop PC or Mac or Android based phones, in the sense that when the app is running in the background, Apple allows only certain functionalities so as to save battery life. This



App drawer showing background apps

means that you cannot expect the Twitter app to pull in updates unless it's in the foreground. But if you are downloading a map, you can minimise that app and do other tasks. Similarly, location polling apps like GPS or direction apps can do so in the background.

Double tapping on the Home button makes the screen transparent and slides it upwards revealing an App Drawer which will show you which apps are present in the background. You can see four apps at a time in the drawer and you will have to swipe left or right

to get the complete picture of the apps in background. At the left most we have the music controller and orientation lock. App-switching is quite snappy. One annoying aspect of this feature is that if you want to get out of an app, you will have to first set it in the background by one tap, and then double tap to reveal the app drawer. Then hold down on that app and then close it.

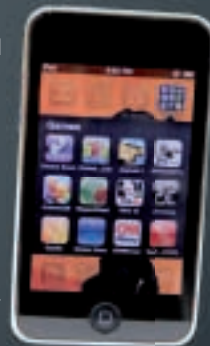
Folders

The Apple store has reached over 200,000 apps and it is safe to assume that we download lots of apps. But before iOS4, the downloaded apps were all over the place.

To create a folder all you have to do is hold down on the app till it starts to jiggle, and then move it over another app to create a folder.

Now the folder is automatically named based on its genre, but as a user you get the option to rename the folder according to your specifications. A single folder can hold up to 12 apps. Having a folder makes organisation of apps very easy i.e. you can name folders based on the apps they contain.

Having folders is great as it helps you organize your apps brilliantly, but you will have to remember which folder has which app, which can get annoying at times. As of now there is no provision to nest one folder into another.



Apps within a folder

Simplifying Email

The Email app has an innovative addition, not seen in the Android phones yet, in the form of Unified inbox. It basically gets email from your multiple mail accounts in one place. This prevents you from jumping in and out of multiple inboxes. On the other hand, this feature may also be too overwhelming for some users, if there are many mails flying around on each account. You can also switch to inboxes of individual accounts.

Installing iOS4

You will need the latest version of iTunes (9.2 and up) which can be downloaded from Apple's website or can be found on our July 2010 Mindware DVD. Once iTunes is installed, all you have to do is connect your device (iPhone or iPod) to your system and go to your device. A summary pane will show a notification of upgrading to new OS. On selecting it you will be guided through the upgrade process.